

# Building the Grid

## The 12-Point System

*A grid you only talked about last class is still just an idea. Tonight it becomes something your file actually holds you to.*

# The File You Already Built

Last class wasn't a separate exercise. It was the foundation. Parent pages, four layers, a saved workspace, four paragraph styles, all of it is still sitting in your file, waiting for tonight to give it something to align to.

## WHAT'S ALREADY THERE

A Cover page, an A-Intro title-page parent, a B-Project project-page parent, applied to real pages, not just built and left sitting in the master spreads.

## What Tonight Adds

Two grids on top of that structure, baseline and modular, plus the one paragraph style setting that was waiting on the baseline to exist: Align to Grid.

# Why Today Matters

The 12-point atomic unit governs every margin, gutter, and module you build tonight.

- 1 Baseline grid: a 12-point ruled sheet the whole page locks to**
- 2 Modular grid: 6 columns, 8 rows, 12 pt gutters, 48 modules**
- 3 Why six columns divides cleanly into halves, thirds, and sixths**
- 4 Closing the loop: Body Text finally gets Align to Grid: All Lines**
- 5 Bringing your own project into the grid you just built**

# The Baseline Grid

A modular grid alone still leaves one thing unresolved: what happens to the lines of text running through it. That's the baseline grid's job.

## WHAT IT IS

An invisible ruled sheet across the whole page, twelve points apart, that every line of body text locks to. Think of the modular grid as the concrete, and the baseline grid as the rebar buried inside it.

## WHY IT MATTERS

Two columns of text, typed independently, still land on the same horizontal lines, spread after spread. Without it, left-column and right-column text quietly drift apart by the bottom of the page, and a reviewer notices even without naming why.

# Set the Baseline Grid

One preference, set once, and every line of body text in the file has somewhere to land.

- 1 Preferences > Grids**
- 2 Start: 0 pt, relative to the top of the page**
- 3 Increment Every: 12 pt, matching the unit governing everything else in this file**

# The Modular Grid

Columns divide the page vertically. Rows divide it horizontally. Together they create modules, the smallest rectangular unit where content is placed.

| SETTING | VALUE | WHY                                                        |
|---------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Columns | 6     | Divides evenly into halves, thirds, and sixths             |
| Rows    | 8     | Enough vertical zones for header, body, and footnote areas |
| Gutter  | 12 pt | Matches the baseline increment for mathematical harmony    |
| Modules | 48    | 6 x 8, the field every layout this term draws from         |

# Set the Modular Grid

Two dialogs, both under Layout, and the 48-module field exists.

- 1**    **Layout > Margins and Columns: set 6 columns, gutter 12 pt**
- 2**    **Layout > Create Guides: set 8 rows, gutter 12 pt, Fit Guides to Margins**
- 3**    **Check Preview: guides should divide the live area cleanly, not the bleed**

# Why Six Columns

Six divides cleanly into halves, thirds, and sixths, so one underlying grid supports dramatically different layouts without ever changing the columns themselves.

| LAYOUT            | COLUMN SPAN    | BEST FOR                                        |
|-------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| <b>2-Column</b>   | 3 + 3          | Image / text pairings, side-by-side comparisons |
| <b>3-Column</b>   | 2 + 2 + 2      | Process pages, multiple drawings                |
| <b>Asymmetric</b> | 2 + 4 or 4 + 2 | Hero image with sidebar text, project intros    |
| <b>Full-Bleed</b> | 6              | A single dominant image or floor plan           |

# Verify the Grid

Pause here. Confirm the math before you build anything on top of it.

- 1 Toggle the baseline grid on: Cmd/Ctrl + Option + '**
- 2 Check every column edge and row line against a 12-point increment**
- 3 If anything is off, fix it now, not after content is already placed on top of it**

# Close the Loop on Paragraph Styles

Last class, Body Text was built but deliberately left unfinished, Align to Grid needed a baseline that didn't exist yet. It exists now.

## THE ONE SETTING THAT WAS WAITING

Window > Styles > Paragraph Styles, double-click Body Text, then Indents and Spacing.

### **Align to Grid: All Lines**

Lines of Body Text across two different columns will now perfectly match up, line for line, even though they were typed independently. This is the alignment principle made literal in the software.

# Bring In Your Project

The grid isn't finished until something real sits inside it.

- 1** Open the images and text already placed in your file from last class
- 2** Arrange them into the grid you just built: snap to real columns and rows, don't eyeball position
- 3** Nothing floating between modules, every element resolves to the grid or it isn't done yet

# Grid Checklist

Confirm every item before you consider tonight's setup finished.

- 1**      **Baseline grid: start 0 pt, 12 pt increments**
- 2**      **Modular grid: 6 columns, 8 rows, 12 pt gutters, 48 modules**
- 3**      **Baseline grid toggled on, every line checked against 12 points**
- 4**      **Body Text set to Align to Grid: All Lines**
- 5**      **Parent pages, four layers, and saved workspace still intact from last class**
- 6**      **Your project's images and text arranged into the grid, nothing floating**

# The Whole System, One Page

Every setting from tonight, on one page, so you can see what each number is actually for.

PHASE 2  
Technical Execution of the "Atomic Unit"

- Document Setup**  
Units: Points | Width: 612pt | Height: 792pt | 14 pages (7 spreads) | Facing Pages
- Baseline Grid**  
Preferences > Grids | Start: 0pt (Top Margin) | Increment: 12pt | View > Show Baseline Grid
- Margins & Columns**  
Layout > Margins and Columns | Top: 36pt | Bottom: 48pt | Inside/Outside: 36pt | 6 columns, 12pt gutter
- Modular Grid (Rows)**  
Layout > Create Guides | 8 rows, 12pt gutter | Fit Guides to: Margins | Result: 7 content lines + 1 gutter

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**Preferences > Grids**

Start:

Relative To:

Increment Every:

OK

A

▶

**Margins and Columns**

Top:  (12x3)

Bottom:  (12x4)

Inside/Outside:

Columns:  Gutter:

OK

B

▶

**Layout > Create Guides**

Rows:

Gutter:

Fit Guides to:

OK

C

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Result: 612 x 792pt Page with Both Grids Active

Modular Grid  
6 columns + 8 rows (blue)

Baseline Grid  
66 lines at 12pt (orange)

Margins  
36 / 48 / 36 / 36pt (dashed)

— Modular grid (6 cols + 8 rows) — Baseline grid (12pt increment)

# Quick Reference

Keep this open while you work.

| ACTION                      | MAC             | WINDOWS          |
|-----------------------------|-----------------|------------------|
| <b>Toggle Baseline Grid</b> | Cmd + Opt + '   | Ctrl + Alt + '   |
| <b>Preview Mode</b>         | W               | W                |
| <b>Show/Hide Guides</b>     | Cmd + ;         | Ctrl + ;         |
| <b>Snap to Guides</b>       | Shift + Cmd + ; | Shift + Ctrl + ; |
| <b>Fit Spread in Window</b> | Opt + Cmd + 0   | Alt + Ctrl + 0   |